tion. Worse, Trump invited Pakistan's self-appointed Field Marshal Asim Munir to a meeting at the White House on June 18, signifying a deepening of their ties, much to India's discomfort. Around the same time, Trump, in a telephonic conversation with Modi, invited him to the White House on his way back from the G7 visit to Canada. The Indian PM declined, saying he was otherwise committed, but not before making the point that India has not accepted third-party mediation in its dispute with Pakistan in the past and would not do so in the future either. This, reportedly, piqued Trump. According to experts, Operation Sindoor became an inflection point not because of differences in policy between the two countries but because India refused to validate Trump's personal narrative and dashed his hopes of winning a Nobel Peace Prize for the many wars he claimed to have stopped. In hindsight, policy experts argue, India could have worked out a via media for acknowledging US role in brokering the ceasefire, which could have satisfied its domestic audience and pleased Trump.

Indo-US ties fell to another low in August when Trump imposed an additional 25 per cent tariff on India for importing oil from Russia, accusing it of funding Moscow's war on Ukraine as well as profiteering from sale to other countries. The resulting 50 per cent tariff saw India joining Brazil among the nations paying the highest tariffs. According to Arun Singh, former Indian ambassador to the US, "The real damage in relations is psychological—the perception is that the US is coercive and unreliable. That shouldn't prevent India from deepening its partnership, but it should hedge. We can do more defence cooperation with the US, but never become security-dependent. The first step must be the US lifting the Russia-related tariffs. Only after that can we realistically talk about rebuilding the momentum." The process of repair is expected to begin once the new US ambassador, Sergio Gor—a Trump confidant—takes charge in mid-January.

Lessons from 2025

Experts view Modi's decision not to react to every Trump taunt and to draw red lines not just on third-party mediation but also to protect farmers' interests in trade negotiations, as sagacious and mature. The Indian PM's engagements with Russian president Vladimir Putin and Chinese president Xi Jinping at the SCO meet in China in September are seen as a clear message to Trump that India has other players in the game.

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The Modi government's move to expand and diversify trade relations by signing deals with the UK, New Zealand and Oman, besides negotiating one with the European Union, should mitigate the impact of the draconian American tariffs on Indian exports.

The lessons from 2025 are clear and will be the priority for Modi and his government in 2026. It was evident at Modi's meeting with the chief secretaries at the end of the year, in which shoring up human resources and skill development emerged as a key area of focus. The prime minister, his aides say, is aware that in an ageing western world, India has to cash in on its demographic dividend. As an expert remarked, India should not become old before it becomes rich.

Trump's return has also forced Modi to reconfigure India's foreign policy calculus, as the US no longer seems to conceive of India as a strategic counterweight to China. The swagger of the past has given way to sobering realism that the US regards India as economically smaller, technologically lagging and strategically ambiguous. India's aspiration for multipolarity must contend with this hard geopolitical reality. Trump didn't change India. What he did was expose Delhi's assumptions about itself. Like an oyster needs a foreign organism as an irritant to secrete layers of nacre in self-defence that eventually form a beautiful pearl, Trump's interventionist approach may push India to explore better possibilities.

It is for Modi and India in 2026 to bring about the necessary recalibration in the country's foreign policy and decide what kind of superpower we want to be. Whether we want to compete with China, or with Pakistan. Whether our states measure themselves against each other for ease of doing business, or with high-flying trade countries like Vietnam and South Korea. Whether we allow our cities, including the national capital, to become hellholes of pollution and corruption, or engineer a civic revolution that facilitates both ease of living and ease of doing business in a harmonious, growth-oriented manner.

Modi is one of the rare leaders who are endowed with a long-horizon vision, which he has demonstrated in the past two decades as prime minister, and who has the wherewithal to steer India through these turbulent times. It is the raft of economic reforms he initiated in 2025 and the resilience he displayed amid an adverse environment, along with Trump's role in the global churn that impacted India over the year, which has made INDIA TODAY hail them as Newsmakers of the Year 2025. ■